BRIGHTWATER ROBOTICS, INC.

Employee Handbook

Part 1: Welcome and Employment Basics

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Applies to	All employees in the US and Canada	**Supersedes**	Handbook v4.1 (2025)

1. Welcome to Brightwater

1.1 Who We Are

Brightwater Robotics, Inc. designs and builds autonomous inspection robots for ports, dams, and offshore infrastructure. The company was founded on August 14, 2011 in Tacoma, Washington by two engineers who were tired of sending people into places that robots could reach. Today we employ roughly 1,400 people across three offices: Tacoma, Washington (headquarters), Austin, Texas, and Toronto, Ontario.

Our mascot is Bolt, a river otter wearing a hard hat. Bolt appears on welcome kits, on the Harbor portal, and on the sign outside the Tacoma Lab. Yes, there is an Otter Day. You can read about it in Part 2.

1.2 Our Values

- **Build it to last.** We make equipment that works in salt water, cold, and years of neglect. We hold our own work to that standard.
- **Say the hard thing kindly.** Direct feedback is a form of respect. Delivering it with care is part of the job.
- **Ship, then learn.** A working version in front of a customer teaches more than a perfect plan.
- **Leave the dock better.** Fix the small thing you notice, even if it is not your job.

1.3 How to Use This Handbook

The Employee Handbook has three parts. Part 1 (this document) covers employment basics. Part 2 covers time off, leave, and benefits. Part 3 covers conduct, information security, and hybrid work. Travel and expense rules are in the separate Travel and Expense Policy.

This handbook describes our policies and practices. It is not a contract of employment, and Brightwater may update it at any time. The current version is always in the Harbor portal under Documents. For questions, email the People Team at peopleteam@brightwater-robotics.example.

2. Your First 90 Days

2.1 The Orientation Period

Your first 90 calendar days are called the Orientation Period. During this time you can use paid time off as it becomes available, but you may not take more than 5 consecutive working days off without your manager's written approval. Health coverage does not wait for the end of the Orientation Period. It starts on the first of the month after your hire date (see Part 2, Section 7).

2.2 Day One

On your first day you will receive your badge, your laptop, and your Harbor account. The welcome session (called Dock Day) starts at 9:00 a.m. local time in the Lakeview Room at Tacoma, or by video for employees in other offices and remote employees. Please complete your tax and direct deposit forms in Harbor within your first 3 business days so that you are paid on the first eligible payday.

2.3 Your Harbor Pilot

Every new hire is matched with a Harbor Pilot, a peer from a different team who has been at Brightwater for at least one year. Your Pilot meets with you for 30 minutes every week for your first 8 weeks, then monthly through day 90. Pilots do not evaluate you. They help you find things and people.

2.4 Check-ins at Day 30, 60, and 90

Your manager will meet with you at day 30, day 60, and day 90. The day-90 conversation is called the Orientation Review. It is a discussion about what is going well and what you need, not a formal rating.

3. Employment Classifications

Your classification determines how your hours are tracked and which benefits you receive. It is stated in your offer letter and visible in Harbor.

Classification	Typical hours	Overtime	Benefits eligibility
Exempt (salaried)	40 per week	Not eligible	Full benefits
Non-exempt (hourly)	Up to 40 per week	1.5 times hourly rate for hours over 40 in a workweek	Full benefits
Part-time	20 to 29 per week	As required by law	401(k) and prorated PTO. Health benefits at 24 or more hours per week.
Fixed-term	Project-based	Per exempt or non-exempt status	Full benefits if the term is 6 months or longer
Summer intern	Up to 40 per week, 12 weeks	As required by law	No PTO. Sick leave as required by law. Not eligible for Otter Day.
Contractor	Not applicable	Not applicable	None. Contractors are not employees.

4. Work Hours, Pay, and Timekeeping

4.1 Standard Workweek and Core Hours

The standard workweek runs Monday through Sunday and is 40 hours. Most teams work flexible schedules around **core hours of 10:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. in your local time zone**. During core hours, you are expected to be reachable for meetings and quick questions.

4.2 Pay Schedule

Brightwater pays every other Friday, for a total of 26 paydays per year. The first payday of 2026 is January 9. If a payday falls on a company holiday, you will be paid on the preceding business day. Direct deposit is required. Pay statements are available in Harbor.

4.3 Timekeeping for Non-Exempt Employees

- Record your hours daily in Harbor. Submit your timesheet by **12:00 noon local time on the Monday after the workweek ends**.
- You receive an unpaid 30-minute meal break on any shift longer than 5 hours, and a paid 10-minute rest break for every 4 hours worked.
- Do not work off the clock. Overtime must be approved in advance by your manager. Unapproved overtime is still paid, but it may lead to a coaching conversation.

4.4 Pay Corrections

Report a suspected pay error to the People Team within 5 business days of the payday. If you were underpaid by more than $100, Brightwater issues an off-cycle payment within 3 business days. Smaller corrections are made on the next regular payday.

5. Performance and Growth

5.1 Review Cycles

Brightwater holds two review cycles each year: the **Spring Review in April** and the **Fall Review in October**. You complete a self-assessment, your manager writes a review, and a panel of managers calibrates ratings across teams. Merit increases are decided in the Spring Review and take effect on July 1. Promotions can be approved in either cycle and take effect on the first pay period after approval.

5.2 Rating Scale

Rating	Label	What it means
5	Exceptional	Results and impact far beyond the role. Reserved for a small share of employees.
4	Strong	Consistently exceeds expectations.
3	Solid	Fully meets expectations. This is where most employees land, and it is a good rating.
2	Developing	Meets some expectations. A clear plan for improvement is needed.
1	Needs improvement	Does not meet expectations. A Growth Plan begins immediately.

5.3 Growth Plans

If performance falls below expectations, your manager and the People Team will create a Growth Plan. A Growth Plan lasts 45 days, includes weekly check-ins, and lists specific goals and the support Brightwater will provide. Successful completion ends the plan. If goals are not met, the next step is described in Part 3, Section 8.

5.4 Internal Moves

You may apply for an internal opening after 12 months in your current role. You must tell your manager before the offer stage, but your manager cannot block a move.

6. Employee Referral Program

Referrals are our best source of hires. If someone you refer is hired, you earn a bonus.

Role type	Referral bonus	Payment timing
Standard roles	$3,000	First paycheck after the referred hire completes 120 days
Roles on the Hard-to-Fill list (posted in Harbor)	$5,000	First paycheck after the referred hire completes 120 days

- Submit the referral in Harbor **before** the candidate applies. Referrals made after an application do not qualify.
- People Team members and the hiring manager for the role are not eligible for a bonus on that hire.
- Bonuses are paid through payroll and are taxable income.

7. Workplace Basics

7.1 Dress Code

Dress is casual. In the Lab areas at Tacoma and Austin, closed-toe shoes are required at all times, and safety glasses are required near active equipment.

7.2 Dog Fridays

Registered dogs are welcome at the Tacoma headquarters on Fridays only. Register your dog in Harbor with proof of vaccination. No more than 3 dogs may be on a floor at one time, and dogs are not allowed in the Lab or the kitchens. Dogs are not permitted at Austin or Toronto.

7.3 Badges and Visitors

Wear your badge while in the building. Visitors must sign in at reception and be escorted at all times. Report a lost or stolen badge to Facilities within 24 hours.

7.4 Parking

Parking is free at the Tacoma and Austin offices. Toronto employees receive the commuter benefit described in Part 2, Section 9.

8. Leaving Brightwater

8.1 Resignation Notice

We ask for 2 weeks of written notice when you resign, and 4 weeks if you are a Director or above.

8.2 Severance

If Brightwater ends your employment for reasons other than misconduct, you are eligible for severance of **1 week of base pay for each full year of service, with a minimum of 2 weeks and a maximum of 16 weeks**. Severance requires you to sign a release of claims.

8.3 Final Pay, Equipment, and Benefits

- Your final paycheck is issued according to the law of your work location. Unused PTO is paid out where required by law.
- Return all Brightwater equipment within **5 business days** of your last day. A prepaid shipping label is provided for remote employees.
- Health, dental, and vision coverage end on the last day of the month in which your employment ends. Information about continuing coverage (COBRA in the US) is mailed within 14 days.
- Your 401(k) account stays with you. Vested balances can be left in the plan or rolled over.

8.4 Rehire and Alumni

Former employees are eligible for rehire unless they were terminated for cause. Everyone who leaves in good standing is invited to join the Brightwater Alumni Network.

Brightwater Robotics, Inc. is a fictional company created for training and demonstration purposes. All policies, figures, systems, names, phone numbers, and addresses in this document are invented.